

Amara's Magic Paintbrush

A story about using your gifts to help others, not just yourself

Written by Daniel Tesfamariam

For children ages 4-10

[Illustration: Beautiful, colorful cover art depicting the main character]

Dedication

To every child with a talent or gift the world needs what only you can give. Use it well.

Page 1

In a small village at the foot of the Purple Mountains, there lived a girl named Amara who loved to paint.

She painted on scraps of paper, on smooth stones, on the walls of her house (which her mother wasn't thrilled about).

Amara painted flowers and birds and sunsets and dragons and anything her imagination could dream up.

But Amara's family was very poor. They couldn't afford real paints or canvases or brushes.

[Illustration: A young girl painting with berry juice on a flat stone outside a small humble village home, her artwork beautiful despite the simple materials, Purple Mountains in the background]

Page 2

One evening, Amara found something extraordinary washed up in the stream behind her house. It was a paintbrush but not an ordinary one. Its handle was carved from golden wood, and its bristles shimmered like they were made of pure starlight.

When Amara picked it up, the brush tingled warmly in her hand, as if it had been waiting for her.

'Hello, beautiful,' Amara whispered, running her thumb along the smooth handle.

[Illustration: Amara kneeling by a stream at sunset, picking up a magnificent golden paintbrush that glows with starlight, her eyes wide with wonder]

Page 3

That night, Amara dipped the brush in a puddle and painted a picture of an apple on her stone floor.

The moment she finished the last stroke, the painted apple shimmered, rose up from the floor, and became REAL.

A perfect, red, delicious apple—solid and warm and smelling like an orchard in autumn.

Amara dropped the brush in shock. She bit the apple. It was the sweetest, most delicious apple she'd ever tasted.

'The brush makes things REAL,' she gasped. 'Whatever I paint comes to life!'

[Illustration: Amara staring in shock as a painted apple lifts off the floor and becomes three-dimensional and real, the magic brush glowing on the ground beside her, apple shining red]

Page 4

The next morning, Amara went wild with excitement. She painted a feast of food for her family.

Bread, fruit, rice, vegetables, warm stew it all came to life on the table.

Her mother and little brother stared in disbelief. 'How?' her mother asked.

'My paintbrush is magic!' Amara beamed. 'We'll never be hungry again!'

Then she painted new clothes for everyone, and a warm blanket for her brother's bed.

[Illustration: A humble table now overflowing with beautiful food that Amara has painted into existence, her mother and brother amazed, Amara proudly holding the golden brush]

Page 5

Amara's mind raced with possibilities. She could have ANYTHING she wanted!

She painted herself a beautiful room with a soft bed. She painted toys and books and sweets.

She painted a big house for her family with a garden and a swing.

For three wonderful days, Amara painted everything her heart desired. Life was perfect!

Or at least... she thought it was.

[Illustration: Amara in a now-beautiful painted room full of toys and books and treats, painting more and more things for herself, surrounded by luxury, looking happy but a little excessive]

Page 6

On the fourth day, Amara's neighbor, old Mrs. Desta, knocked on their door. Her eyes were hollow with hunger. 'Please,' she said quietly. 'My grandchildren haven't eaten in two days. Can you spare anything?'

Amara had a table full of painted food. More than her family could ever eat.

She started to say yes but then a selfish thought crept in. 'What if the brush's magic runs out? I should save everything for MY family.'

'Sorry, Mrs. Desta,' Amara said. 'We don't have enough to share.' It was a lie.

[Illustration: Old Mrs. Desta at the door looking thin and desperate, Amara with a conflicted guilty expression, a lavish table of food clearly visible behind her in the house]

Page 7

That night, something strange happened. When Amara tried to paint more food, the colors looked... duller.

The bread she painted came out stale. The fruit was dry. The magic seemed weaker.

'That's odd,' Amara thought. She tried painting a new dress. It appeared, but the colors were faded and the fabric was thin.

The brush was losing its magic. Amara felt a prick of panic. What was happening?

[Illustration: Amara painting but the results looking dull and faded, a loaf of bread appearing stale and gray, the brush's glow dimmer than before, Amara looking worried]

Page 8

By the next day, the brush barely worked at all. Amara painted a bowl of soup and got a bowl of cold, tasteless water.

She painted a warm coat and got a thin sheet of paper.

'No! No no no!' Amara cried, shaking the brush. 'What happened? Why won't you work?'

Then she heard a gentle voice coming from the brush itself.

'I was given to you to help others,' the brush whispered. 'Magic that is only used for yourself... fades.'

[Illustration: Amara shaking the dimly glowing brush in frustration, failed paintings around her watery soup, paper-thin coat the brush glowing faintly with a gentle voice coming from it]

Page 9

'When you turned away Mrs. Desta and her hungry grandchildren, my magic began to die,' the brush said.

'I'm meant to flow outward, like water from a spring. When you dam it up for yourself alone, I dry up.'

Amara felt a deep shame settle in her stomach. She had been so focused on getting things for herself that she'd forgotten the people around her who needed help.

'Can I fix it?' she asked in a small voice. 'Can the magic come back?'

'Use me for others,' the brush said. 'And see what happens.'

[Illustration: Amara sitting on the floor, the dim brush in her lap, tears in her eyes, looking ashamed and thoughtful, the once-beautiful painted room now looking faded around her]

Page 10

Amara ran straight to Mrs. Desta's house. 'I'm so sorry!' she cried. 'I have something that can help.'

She dipped the brush and painted a meal for Mrs. Desta and her grandchildren.

As the brush swept across the stone, it glowed bright brighter than it had in days!

A magnificent feast appeared: warm injera bread, rich stew, fresh fruit, and cool water.

The magic was back. And it was STRONGER than before. Helping others made the brush's power surge.

[Illustration: Amara painting a beautiful feast at Mrs. Desta's humble table, the brush glowing brilliantly, Mrs. Desta's grandchildren cheering with joy, food appearing magical and vibrant]

Page 11

'Thank you, child!' Mrs. Desta wept with gratitude, hugging Amara tight. The grandchildren danced around the table. Their smiles lit up the room brighter than any magic. Amara felt something warm bloom in her chest a feeling much better than having a big house or fancy clothes. It was the feeling of making someone else's life better. And it was addictive in the best way.

[Illustration: Mrs. Desta hugging Amara while the grandchildren eat happily, everyone smiling, the room glowing with warmth and gratitude, Amara's face showing deep satisfaction]

Page 12

From that moment on, Amara used her brush for the village.

She painted a new well so everyone had clean water. The brush blazed like gold!

She painted a school building so the children had a place to learn. The brush hummed with power!

She painted medicine for the sick, seeds for the farmers, and warm blankets for the cold nights.

Every time she helped someone else, the brush grew more powerful, not less.

[Illustration: A montage of Amara painting wonderful things for her village a well, a school, medicine the brush glowing more and more brilliantly with each selfless act]

Page 13

Word spread about Amara and her magical paintbrush. People came from far villages asking for help.

A farmer whose crops had failed. A family whose house had burned. A child who needed medicine.

Amara helped every single one. And with each act of generosity, the brush grew brighter and more powerful.

She discovered something amazing: the more she gave away, the more magic she had to give. It never ran out when she used it for others.

[Illustration: A line of people from various villages coming to Amara for help, Amara painting solutions for each one, the brush now blazing like a golden torch]

Page 14

But one day, a rich and greedy man named Mr. Hailu came to the village.

'Give me that brush!' he demanded. 'I'll use it to paint myself a palace of gold!'

'No,' Amara said calmly. 'The brush only works when used to help others. It dies when used for greed.'

Mr. Hailu didn't believe her. He grabbed the brush from her hand and tried to paint gold coins.

The brush was cold and dead in his hands. Nothing happened. Not even a flicker.

[Illustration: A greedy-looking wealthy man trying to use the paintbrush to paint gold coins, the brush completely dark and lifeless in his hands, Amara watching with a knowing expression]

Page 15

'Why won't it work?!' Mr. Hailu shouted, shaking the brush furiously.

'Because it knows your heart,' Amara said gently. 'The brush is powered by generosity. It can feel why you want to paint.'

'If you paint to help others it blazes like the sun. If you paint for selfish greed it sleeps.'

Mr. Hailu threw the brush down in frustration and stormed away.

Amara picked it up, and it immediately warmed in her hands, glowing softly, happy to be home.

[Illustration: Mr. Hailu angrily throwing the dead brush down and storming off, Amara calmly picking it up as it immediately glows warm and golden again in her gentle hands]

Page 16

One day, a terrible drought came to the region. The stream dried up and the fields cracked.

Amara painted rain clouds above the fields and real rain fell, soft and nourishing, saving the crops.

The brush blazed so brightly it was hard to look at. 'This is what I'm for!' it seemed to sing.

Amara laughed with joy, dancing in the rain she'd created for everyone.

[Illustration: Amara painting rain clouds over dry cracked fields, real rain falling from the painted clouds, farmers dancing in the rain, the brush blazing like the sun]

Page 17

Then word came of a village across the mountains where children had no school.

Amara traveled there with her brush and painted desks, books, chalkboards, and even a roof over their heads.

The children cheered and hugged her. 'You're a miracle!' they cried.

'No,' Amara said gently. 'I just have a tool. The miracle is what you'll learn and become.

That's up to you.'

She taught the oldest child to read, and left the village glowing with hope.

[Illustration: Amara in a faraway village, painting a school into existence, children cheering and grabbing the books eagerly, the brush creating desks and supplies]

Page 18

As years passed, Amara's village became the most beautiful and prosperous in all the land. Not because everyone was rich but because everyone had what they needed, and they all helped each other.

Amara had painted the village back to life. But more than that, her generosity had inspired others.

Farmers shared their harvests. Builders helped fix each other's homes. Children helped younger children learn.

Amara's brush had started something, and the village's own kindness kept it going.

[Illustration: A thriving, beautiful village with happy people working together, gardens blooming, children playing, a community transformed by generosity and mutual support]

Page 19

Amara learned that the happiest she ever felt was NOT when she painted things for herself. It was when she saw a child eat a meal she'd painted, or a family sleep warm under a blanket she'd created.

The joy of helping others was like a light inside her chest that never went out.

Her selfish wishes had given her a moment of happiness. But her generous acts gave her a lifetime of it.

'This is what the brush was teaching me all along,' she realized. 'My gift is not FOR me. It's THROUGH me.'

[Illustration: Amara watching children play in a schoolyard she painted, her hand over her heart, a glow of deep contentment and purpose, understanding her role as a giver]

Page 20

One evening, Amara sat painting a sunset on the hillside just for the joy of it. Her mother sat beside her. 'I remember when you only painted for yourself,' her mother said.

'I'm glad I stopped,' Amara replied. 'Painting for myself made me feel full for a moment. But painting for others fills me up forever.'

'That's because gifts are like seeds,' her mother said. 'When you plant them in others, they grow into something much bigger than what you started with.'

[Illustration: Amara and her mother sitting on a hillside at sunset, Amara painting the real sunset with her glowing brush, a peaceful reflective scene of contentment and wisdom]

Page 21

Amara also discovered something beautiful the brush worked best when she was joyful while painting.

If she painted while feeling grateful and happy, the colors were brighter, the food tastier, the blankets warmer.

But if she painted out of duty or resentment, the results were ordinary.

'Paint with love,' the brush whispered to her. 'That's the real ingredient. Not magic love.'

And Amara did. Every single day, with love.

[Illustration: Amara painting with a huge smile, the brush producing spectacular vibrant creations when she paints with love, colors more vivid than a rainbow, love visible as golden sparkles]

Page 22

When Amara grew old, she passed the brush to a young boy in the village who loved to paint as much as she once had.

'Remember,' she told him, 'this brush has one rule: use it for others, and it will never fail you. Use it only for yourself, and it will sleep.'

The boy nodded seriously. 'I'll paint for everyone, Amara. I promise.'

And he did. Generation after generation, the brush was passed to a new painter with a generous heart.

[Illustration: An elderly Amara handing the golden brush to a young boy artist, both looking at each other with deep understanding, the brush glowing between them, a passing-of-the-torch moment]

Page 23

Now, dear reader, here's what Amara wants you to know:

You may not have a magic paintbrush, but you DO have gifts.

Maybe you're good at sports, or math, or making people laugh, or being a good listener, or drawing, or building things.

Whatever your gift is it works the same way as Amara's brush.

Use it to help others, and it will grow stronger and bring you more joy than you can imagine. Keep it only for yourself, and it slowly fades away.

[Illustration: A child looking at their own hands, realizing their hands hold invisible gifts, a warm glow emanating from them, inspired by Amara's story to use their talents for good]

Page 24

Here are some ways YOUR gifts can be a magic paintbrush:

If you are good at reading, read to someone who is learning. If you are good at sports, teach a younger child to play.

If you are funny, make someone laugh on their worst day. If you are a good listener, sit with someone who needs to talk.

If you can draw, make art that makes people smile. If you are strong, carry something heavy for someone who cannot.

Every gift shared is a painting brought to life. Every talent used for others is magic made real.

[Illustration: Children using different gifts to help each other – reading together, teaching sports, making art for others – each child's hands glowing like they hold a magic brush]

Page 25

And remember Amara's most important lesson:

The joy of using your gift for yourself lasts a moment. The joy of using it for others lasts forever.

So paint your world with generosity. Use what you have been given to make life more beautiful for everyone around you.

That is the real magic. Not in the brush. In the heart that chooses to share.

Your heart. Your gift. Your magic. Go paint something wonderful.

[Illustration: A final image of a golden paintbrush resting in a child's hand, the child looking at the world with determination to use their gifts for good, golden light streaming outward]

The Moral of the Story

Use Your Gifts to Help Others, Not Just Yourself

Amara discovered that her magic paintbrush grew stronger when she used it for others and faded when she used it selfishly. Our gifts and talents work the same way! When we share what we're good at with others – helping, teaching, creating, comforting – it brings us more happiness than keeping everything for ourselves. Your unique ability is meant to make the world better. So share it freely, and watch it grow.

Discussion Questions for Parents

After reading this story together, talk about these questions:

1. What gifts or talents do YOU have? (Remember, a gift can be anything kindness counts too!)
2. How could you use your gift to help someone else this week?
3. Why do you think the brush stopped working when Amara was selfish, and grew stronger when she was generous?
4. Have you ever felt really good after helping someone? What did you do?
5. If you had Amara's magic paintbrush for one day, what would you paint to help people?

About the Author

Daniel Tesfamariam is a storyteller who believes every child deserves stories that spark imagination, build character, and fill hearts with wonder.

His stories are crafted to help children understand important life lessons through adventure, friendship, and the magic of imagination.

When not writing, Daniel enjoys spending time with family, exploring nature, and dreaming up new worlds for young readers to discover.

Thank you for reading! If your child enjoyed this story, please look for other books in the collection.